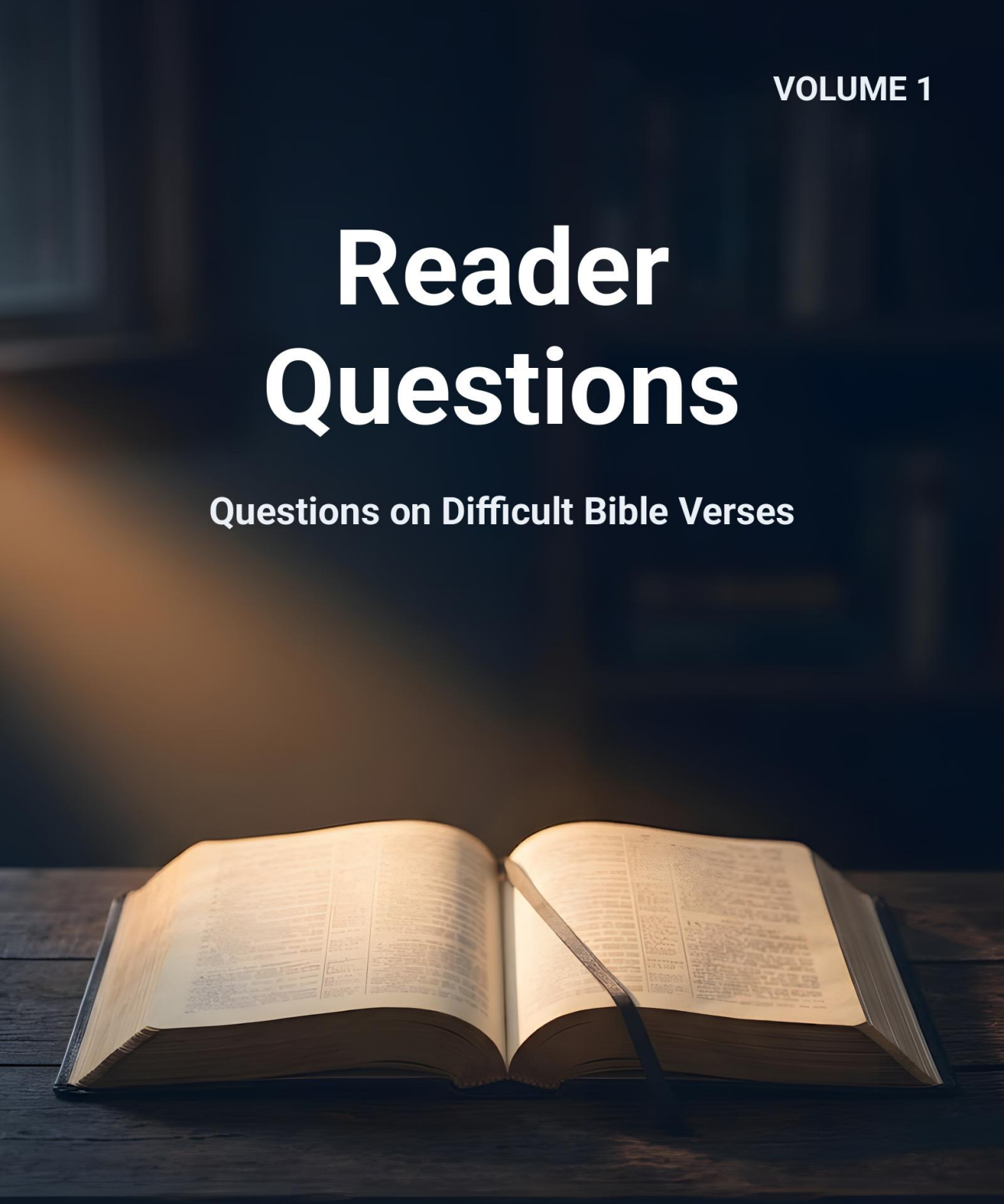
VOLUME 1

Reader Questions

Questions on Difficult Bible Verses



READERS QUESTION SERIES

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Volume 1: Questions on Difficult Bible Verses

HOW TO READ THIS VOLUME

Each entry takes one question a reader has asked about one verse or short passage. It states what the verse means, and then argues that meaning from the verse's own passage and the chapter or chapters before it. The Scripture elsewhere is used as support, not as the foundation. Each entry marks what the text states, what the context shows, and what is inferred, so that the reader can see what carries the weight and judge it. The entries argue a position. Where other readings are held by named writers, they are set beside it with the places where each strains.

Scripture is quoted from the King James Version (KJV). Modern writers are named by author and work; their views are described in the entry's own words, and no quotation marks are used for them.

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1. What Is “the Falling Away” in 2 Thessalonians 2:3?

THE ANSWER

The falling away is the departure of the Body of Christ, the gathering to the Lord that must take place before the day of the Lord begins. Paul is not warning believers of a coming collapse of faith. He is assuring them that they are not in the day.

Where the Verse Stands

Second Thessalonians 2 opens with a request: “by the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ, and by our gathering together unto him,” do not be shaken in mind or troubled (2:1–2). The cause of the trouble was a report, by spirit, word or letter “as from us,” that “the day of Christ is at hand.” The Thessalonians had been told in the first letter that the dead in Christ would rise and the living be caught up to meet the Lord (1 Thessalonians 4:13–18). The report now said the day had come. Their fear was not that faith would fail; it was that they had been left behind. Verse 3 is Paul’s answer to that fear.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
2:1–2	“Now we beseech you, brethren, by the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ, and by our gathering together unto him, That ye be not soon shaken in mind, or be troubled, neither by spirit, nor by word, nor by letter as from us, as that the day of Christ is at hand.”	The request rests on the gathering. The fear is that the day is “at hand.”
2:3	“Let no man deceive you by any means: for that day shall not come, except there come a falling away first, and that man of sin be revealed, the son of perdition;”	Two events come before “that day.” The falling away is named first.
2:6–7	“And now ye know what withholdeth that he might be revealed in his time. For the mystery of iniquity doth already work: only he who now letteth will let, until he be taken out of the way.”	A neuter “what” and a masculine “he.” One is “taken out of the way.”
2:8	“And then shall that Wicked be revealed, whom the Lord shall consume with the spirit of his mouth, and shall destroy with the brightness of his coming:”	“Then”: the revealing follows the removal.

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** “that day shall not come, except there come a falling away first, and that man of sin be revealed.” Two events come before the day, and the falling away is named first.
- **Stated:** the chapter opens with “our gathering together unto him,” the subject of the comfort.
- **Shown by the context:** the answer is given as comfort. Verse 13 turns to “we are bound to give thanks alway to God for you, brethren beloved of the Lord,” a

reassurance and not a rebuke. A warning of mass apostasy would not answer a fear of having missed the gathering.

- **Shown by the context:** verses 6–8 say that the one who holds back is "taken out of the way" before the Wicked is revealed. The order is the departure, then the revealing, then the day.
- **Inferred:** that the one who holds back is the Body in the world, whose presence is the means of the restraint. The text gives a neuter "what withholdeth" (2:6) and a masculine "he who now letteth" (2:7) and does not name who it is. The Body fits both the grammar, as a company and as its members, and the sequence.

The Word "Falling Away"

The noun is *apostasia*, from a verb meaning to stand away or remove. The KJV chose "falling away." In Acts 21:21 the same noun is used of a defection, "to forsake Moses," and the related verb is used of departing from the faith in 1 Timothy 4:1. Those uses are real. They show the word can mean a spiritual defection. They do not decide the question here, because the sense is settled by what Paul is answering, and he is answering a fear about a gathering that has not yet happened.

The Other Readings

A mass apostasy. Many modern commentaries read a great defection from the faith in the last days, citing 1 Timothy 4:1 and Matthew 24:10–12, where "many" are offended and "the love of many shall wax cold." This reading must say who falls away, and the answer places believers inside the day Paul says they are not in. **The restrainer as the Holy Spirit.** John Walvoord holds this in his writing on prophecy, and it is the main rival for 2:6–7. It explains the neuter and masculine forms by the Spirit, but the chapter never names the Spirit, and it must explain how the Spirit is "taken out of the way" while many are saved in the day that follows. **The restrainer as Rome or human government.** This rests on history outside the passage and has the restrainer removed long before the man is revealed, which does not fit a sequence still ahead.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Departure of the Body	The gathering comes first; the restrainer is the Body's presence.	The restrainer is not named in the text.
Mass apostasy	A defection from the faith precedes the day.	The comfort of the chapter; believers placed in the day.
Holy Spirit as restrainer	The Spirit is taken out of the way.	The Spirit is never named; many are saved in the day that follows.
Rome or government	A historical power is removed.	Removal long past; the sequence is still ahead.

What It Means for the Reader

The believer is not waiting for the day to arrive and hoping to be spared. The gathering comes first, and the comfort Paul gave the Thessalonians is the comfort of the first letter: "Then we which are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds, to meet the Lord in the air: and so shall we ever be with the Lord" (1 Thessalonians 4:17).

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 74, The Man of Sin, reports 2 Thessalonians 2 as written and leaves the falling away and the restrainer open; this entry argues a position.
Commentary Series: Prophecy & Mystery, Volume 4, on the order of the risings.
Companions: 2 Thessalonians and 1 Thessalonians.

2. What Was Paul's "Thorn in the Flesh"?

THE ANSWER

The thorn was opposition: a messenger of Satan sent to buffet Paul in his ministry. It was not an illness. The Lord's answer, "My grace is sufficient for thee," meets that pressure, and Paul's own list that follows is of reproaches, necessities, persecutions and distresses.

Where the Verse Stands

The thorn comes late in a long defence. In chapters 10 to 13 Paul answers men who set themselves up against his apostleship, and he calls them "false apostles, deceitful workers, transforming themselves into the apostles of Christ" (11:13). He answers them by a list of what his ministry has cost him (11:23–28), and then by a revelation he was given, in which a man in Christ was "caught up to the third heaven" (12:2). The thorn is given because of that revelation, "lest I should be exalted above measure."

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
11:13–15	"For such are false apostles, deceitful workers, transforming themselves into the apostles of Christ. And no marvel; for Satan himself is transformed into an angel of light. Therefore it is no great thing if his ministers also be transformed as the ministers of righteousness; whose end shall be according to their works."	Satan works through men who oppose Paul's ministry.
11:26	"In journeyings often, in perils of waters, in perils of robbers, in perils by mine own countrymen, in perils by the heathen, in perils in the city, in perils in the wilderness, in perils in the sea, in perils among false brethren;"	Perils from people, named by source.
12:7	"And lest I should be exalted above measure through the abundance of the revelations, there was given to me a thorn in the flesh, the messenger of Satan to buffet me, lest I should be exalted above measure."	The thorn is "the messenger of Satan." Its purpose is stated.
12:9–10	"And he said unto me, My grace is sufficient for thee: for my strength is made perfect in weakness. Most gladly therefore will I rather glory in my infirmities, that the power of Christ may rest upon me. Therefore I take pleasure in infirmities, in reproaches, in necessities, in persecutions, in distresses for Christ's sake: for when I am weak, then am I strong."	"Infirmities" stands beside reproaches, necessities, persecutions and distresses.

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** the thorn is "the messenger of Satan to buffet me," and it was "given to me." It is a person or agent sent against Paul, and it is permitted for a stated

purpose.

- **Shown by the context:** the whole of chapters 10 to 13 is about opponents. Satan's ministers (11:15) and "false brethren" (11:26) are the people named in the lead-up, and the thorn follows them in the same defence.
- **Shown by the context:** Paul's summary in 12:10 is a list of pressures from outside: reproaches, necessities, persecutions, distresses. It names no sickness.
- **Inferred:** that the thorn is the opposition to his ministry in the same argument. The text calls it a messenger of Satan and does not name a person or a company.
- **Inferred:** that the figure is the familiar one. In Numbers 33:55, Joshua 23:13 and Judges 2:3, the peoples left in the land become thorns and snares to Israel. Paul does not quote these, and the entry does not rest on them.

The Other Readings

A bodily illness. This is the most common popular reading. It is usually built on Galatians 4:13–15, where Paul speaks of "infirmity of the flesh" and of the Galatians' readiness to give him their eyes, and it takes "in the flesh" in 12:7 as a reference to the body. Ralph Martin (*2 Corinthians*, Word Biblical Commentary) surveys the range of views and judges that the thorn cannot be identified with certainty. The reading has to explain why a sickness is called Satan's messenger and why Paul's own list in 12:10 does not include one. **A temptation.** This reads the thorn as an inward struggle with sin. The text says the thorn is "to buffet" him from outside and that he "besought the Lord thrice that it might depart." **An opponent or the opposition.** This is the reading taken here.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Opposition to his ministry	A messenger of Satan raised against Paul's ministry.	The text names no person or group.
Bodily illness	A sickness that Satan's messenger inflicts.	The chapter's list names pressures from people, not sickness.
Inward temptation	A struggle with sin.	Called a buffeting from outside, given because of the revelations.

What It Means for the Reader

The passage is not a pattern for refused healing and does not tell the reader to read every weakness as a thorn. It is Paul's answer to the opposition he met in the ministry committed to him, and the Lord's answer is that his grace is enough and that power is "made perfect in weakness."

Related Reading

Companions: 2 Corinthians.

3. Is “the Last Trump” the Seventh Trumpet of Revelation?

THE ANSWER

No. The last trump of 1 Corinthians 15 and the trump of God of 1 Thessalonians 4 are the Body’s trumpet, sounded at a gathering Paul calls a mystery. The seventh trumpet of Revelation 11:15 sounds for the kingdoms of this world to become the Lord’s, and Paul never mentions it.

Where the Verse Stands

First Corinthians 15 argues for the resurrection of the dead, and at verse 50 Paul turns to a new subject: “Behold, I shew you a mystery.” The trumpet belongs to that mystery. First Thessalonians 4:13–18 gives the same event to a church grieving its dead, and names “the trump of God.” Revelation 11:15–18 is a different scene in a different book, with its own audience and its own result.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
1 Cor 15:51–52	“Behold, I shew you a mystery; We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed, In a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trump: for the trumpet shall sound, and the dead shall be raised incorruptible, and we shall be changed.”	A mystery, shown to “you.” The trumpet raises the dead and changes the living.
1 Thess 4:16–17	“For the Lord himself shall descend from heaven with a shout, with the voice of the archangel, and with the trump of God: and the dead in Christ shall rise first: Then we which are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds, to meet the Lord in the air: and so shall we ever be with the Lord.”	The trump of God. The result is meeting the Lord and being with him.
Rev 11:15	“And the seventh angel sounded; and there were great voices in heaven, saying, The kingdoms of this world are become the kingdoms of our Lord, and of his Christ; and he shall reign for ever and ever.”	The seventh angel. The result is the kingdom.
Rev 11:18	“And the nations were angry, and thy wrath is come, and the time of the dead, that they should be judged, and that thou shouldest give reward unto thy servants the prophets, and to the saints, and them that fear thy name, small and great; and shouldest destroy them which destroy the earth.”	Anger, wrath, judgment, reward, destruction.

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** Paul introduces the trumpet as part of “a mystery” (1 Corinthians 15:51), something shown to the Corinthians that had not been shown before.
- **Stated:** the two Pauline passages share a trumpet, a rising of the dead, a change of the living and being with the Lord. Revelation 11 shares the word “trumpet” and

the dead, but the result is the kingdom, wrath and judgment, and reward to servants.

- **Shown by the context:** the word "last" closes Paul's own sentence. He gives the Corinthians no series of trumpets to count and names no seventh. Revelation 11 is in a book of seals, trumpets and bowls, where the trumpets are numbered.
- **Shown by the context:** Paul tells the Thessalonians to "comfort one another with these words" (4:18). The trumpet of Revelation 11 brings the nations' anger and God's wrath (11:18), which is not what Paul offers as comfort.
- **Inferred:** that "last" means the last call of the Body, the final trumpet in Paul's own use, and not the last in Revelation's numbered series. The text does not say which series "last" belongs to, and the argument rests on the audience and the result.

The Other Readings

The same trumpet. George Eldon Ladd (*The Blessed Hope*) argues that the gathering comes at the end of the tribulation. Writers who hold that view commonly read Paul's trumpet together with the final trumpet of Revelation. The reading places the church in the scenes that Revelation 11:18 describes as wrath. **Separate trumpets.** John Walvoord (*The Rapture Question*) argues that the gathering precedes the tribulation, and writers who hold that view commonly read Paul's trumpet as distinct from Revelation's. That is the reading taken here, and the entry argues it from the two passages' own settings.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Same trumpet as Revelation 11:15	The gathering comes at the seventh trumpet.	Different audience, result and sequence; believers placed under the wrath of 11:18.
Distinct trumpets	Paul's trumpet gathers the Body; Revelation's announces the kingdom.	"Last" has to be read within Paul's own sentence.

What It Means for the Reader

The hope of 1 Thessalonians 4 does not wait for the sequence of Revelation's trumpets. The Body's trumpet and Revelation's seventh trumpet sound for different companies and different results, and the reader should not carry the scenes of Revelation 11 into 1 Corinthians 15.

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 49, The Resurrections of Scripture, reports the passages as written. **Commentary Series:** Prophecy & Mystery, Volume 4. **Companions:** 1 Thessalonians.

4. Is Salvation by Repentance or by Belief?

THE ANSWER

The Body is saved by believing the gospel Paul preached, by grace through faith and not of works. Repentance is the change of mind that goes with believing. The passages that command it are each addressed in their own setting, and none of them adds a second ground to the gospel of grace.

Where the Question Comes From

The question arises because Scripture uses the word "repent" in several places and in several settings, and because Peter's words to Israel, "Repent, and be baptized," sound very different from Paul's "by grace are ye saved through faith." The way through is to read each passage where it stands, with its audience, and to ask what each says the hearer must do and what it says the hearer is saved by.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
1 Cor 15:1–4	"Moreover, brethren, I declare unto you the gospel which I preached unto you, which also ye have received, and wherein ye stand; By which also ye are saved, if ye keep in memory what I preached unto you, unless ye have believed in vain. For I delivered unto you first of all that which I also received, how that Christ died for our sins according to the scriptures; And that he was buried, and that he rose again the third day according to the scriptures:"	The gospel Paul preached, and what saves.
Eph 2:8–9	"For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves: it is the gift of God: Not of works, lest any man should boast."	Grace, faith, not of works.
Acts 2:38	"Then Peter said unto them, Repent, and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the remission of sins, and ye shall receive the gift of the Holy Ghost."	Repentance and baptism together, in Peter's message at Jerusalem.
Acts 3:19	"Repent ye therefore, and be converted, that your sins may be blotted out, when the times of refreshing shall come from the presence of the Lord."	Tied to "times of refreshing" from the Lord.
Acts 17:30–31	"And the times of this ignorance God winked at; but now commandeth all men every where to repent: Because he hath appointed a day, in the which he will judge the world in righteousness by that man whom he hath ordained; whereof he hath given assurance unto all men, in that he hath raised him from the dead."	Paul to Gentiles. A command, with a day and a resurrection as the reason.

Acts 20:21	"Testifying both to the Jews, and also to the Greeks, repentance toward God, and faith toward our Lord Jesus Christ."	Two things named together in Paul's testimony.
Acts 26:20	"But shewed first unto them of Damascus, and at Jerusalem, and throughout all the coasts of Judaea, and then to the Gentiles, that they should repent and turn to God, and do works meet for repentance."	Works "meet for" repentance: fitting it, not earning.
2 Cor 7:9–10	"Now I rejoice, not that ye were made sorry, but that ye sorrowed to repentance: for ye were made sorry after a godly manner, that ye might receive damage by us in nothing. For godly sorrow worketh repentance to salvation not to be repented of: but the sorrow of the world worketh death."	Written to a church already addressed as saved.
Rom 2:4	"Or despisest thou the riches of his goodness and forbearance and longsuffering; not knowing that the goodness of God leadeth thee to repentance?"	God's goodness leads to repentance.

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** Paul's gospel is "Christ died for our sins… was buried… rose again the third day," and the saved are those who "have believed" it (1 Corinthians 15:1–4). Ephesians 2:8–9 says the same: grace, faith, "not of works."
- **Stated:** Peter's words in Acts 2:38 and 3:19 join repentance to baptism, to "the remission of sins" and to "times of refreshing" that come "from the presence of the Lord." Paul does not join repentance to baptism or to the times of refreshing in any passage on this list.
- **Shown by the context:** Peter's words to Israel are program-specific. They belong to the offer of the kingdom to Israel in the early chapters of Acts and are not made a condition of the Body's salvation. Repentance, baptism and covenant readiness are never the Body's ground.
- **Shown by the context:** When Paul names repentance, he names it with faith (20:21) or as what God's goodness produces (Romans 2:4). In 26:20 the "works meet for repentance" are what fits the change, not what earns it.
- **Shown by the context:** Second Corinthians 7:10 is written to a church Paul already calls saved. The "salvation" there is not the entry point, and the sorrow in view is over a wrong done among believers.
- **Inferred:** that "repent" in Paul's ministry names the change of mind that turns from idols or from self-righteousness to God, and that it is not a separate act that must be added to faith. The text pairs the words and does not define "repent" in a sentence of its own.

The Other Readings

Repentance as part of saving faith. John MacArthur (*The Gospel According to Jesus*) holds that repentance is integral to saving faith and that the faith that saves is a faith that submits. This reading takes Peter's and Paul's words as one message.
Repentance not required for justification. Zane Hodges (*Absolutely Free!*) holds that the only condition of eternal life is believing, and that repentance is a matter of Christian living. Charles Ryrie (*So Great Salvation*) takes a similar view of the free gift while treating repentance as the change of mind that belongs to believing.

Repentance as a separate condition. This reading adds repentance to belief as something done before salvation, and it has to make Acts 2:38 and Ephesians 2:8–9 one message.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
A change of mind that goes with believing	Repentance and faith are one turning toward God.	"Repent" is rarely defined in the text.
Part of saving faith (Lordship)	Saving faith includes submission.	Ephesians 2:8–9 says "not of works."
Not required (free grace)	Belief alone is the condition.	Acts 20:21 names repentance beside faith.
A separate step	Repent first, then believe.	Makes Acts 2:38 and Ephesians 2:8–9 one message.

What It Means for the Reader

The reader is not asked to complete a list. The gospel Paul preached is believed, and the believer is saved. Where Scripture says repent, it is asking for a real change of mind toward God, not an added work, and it is addressed to the hearers it names.

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 54, Justification; Study 20, Understanding Acts 2:38.
Companions: Acts.

5. Why Were Sodom and Gomorrah Destroyed?

THE ANSWER

Scripture names more than one sin, and none is left out. Genesis gives a great cry and a grievous sin, and the city's men at Lot's door; Ezekiel gives pride, fulness of bread, idleness and neglect of the poor; Jude gives fornication and going after strange flesh. The judgment is the Lord's, and the sins belong together.

Where the Question Comes From

The account is often reduced to one sin, and different readers reduce it to different ones. The reasonable way is to read the account in Genesis 18 and 19 and then let Ezekiel, Jude and Peter say what they say about it, without making any one of them the whole answer.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
Gen 18:20–21	"And the Lord said, Because the cry of Sodom and Gomorrah is great, and because their sin is very grievous; I will go down now, and see whether they have done altogether according to the cry of it, which is come unto me; and if not, I will know."	The cry is "great" and the sin "very grievous." The Lord goes down to see.
Gen 19:4–5	"But before they lay down, the men of the city, even the men of Sodom, compassed the house round, both old and young, all the people from every quarter: And they called unto Lot, and said unto him, Where are the men which came in to thee this night? bring them out unto us, that we may know them."	All the people, "both old and young." The demand is for the guests.
Gen 19:24–25	"Then the Lord rained upon Sodom and upon Gomorrah brimstone and fire from the Lord out of heaven; And he overthrew those cities, and all the plain, and all the inhabitants of the cities, and that which grew upon the ground."	The judgment is from the Lord, on the cities and the plain.
Ezek 16:49–50	"Behold, this was the iniquity of thy sister Sodom, pride, fulness of bread, and abundance of idleness was in her and in her daughters, neither did she strengthen the hand of the poor and needy. And they were haughty, and committed abomination before me: therefore I took them away as I saw good."	Pride, plenty, idleness, no help for the poor; then "abomination."
Jude 7	"Even as Sodom and Gomorrha, and the cities about them in like manner, giving themselves over to fornication, and going after strange flesh, are set forth for an example, suffering the vengeance of eternal fire."	Fornication and "strange flesh." The cities are "an example."

2 Pet 2:6–8	"And turning the cities of Sodom and Gomorrha into ashes condemned them with an overthrow, making them an ensample unto those that after should live ungodly; And delivered just Lot, vexed with the filthy conversation of the wicked: (For that righteous man dwelling among them, in seeing and hearing, vexed his righteous soul from day to day with their unlawful deeds;)"	An ensample. Lot vexed by "unlawful deeds," day after day.

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** the Lord says the sin is "very grievous" before the angels reach the city (Genesis 18:20). The judgment was not triggered by one night.
- **Stated:** in Genesis 19:4–5 the whole population, "both old and young, all the people from every quarter," surrounds the house and demands the visitors "that we may know them."
- **Stated:** Ezekiel says "this was the iniquity of thy sister Sodom" and names pride, fulness of bread, idleness and no strength for the poor, and then adds that "they were haughty, and committed abomination."
- **Stated:** Jude says the cities gave themselves "over to fornication" and went "after strange flesh." Peter says Lot was vexed "from day to day with their unlawful deeds."
- **Inferred:** that the account does not allow a single cause. Ezekiel's "this was the iniquity" names pride and neglect of the poor as the root condition, and Genesis and Jude name the violent sexual sin as the act the root produced. The prophets and apostles do not set them against each other.

The Other Readings

Sexual sin alone. The traditional reading rests on Genesis 19:4–5 and Jude 7 and treats Ezekiel as secondary. It does not account for Ezekiel's "this was the iniquity." **Inhospitality alone.** Derrick Sherwin Bailey (*Homosexuality and the Western Christian Tradition*) argued that the sin was a violation of the duty to receive strangers. This reading has to explain Jude's "fornication" and "strange flesh," and the demand of the whole city for the guests. **Pride and injustice alone.** This takes Ezekiel 16:49 as the full answer. It leaves Jude 7 and the account of Genesis 19 unexplained.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
All the named sins	Pride and neglect of the poor, with the violent sexual sin.	None is set as the only cause; the passages are read together.
Sexual sin alone	Genesis 19 and Jude 7 are the whole.	Ezekiel 16:49 says "this was the iniquity."
Inhospitality alone	The sin was violating strangers.	Jude names "fornication" and "strange flesh."
Pride and injustice alone	Ezekiel 16:49 is the whole.	Genesis 19 and Jude 7 are left out.

What It Means for the Reader

The account does not give the reader one sin to condemn in others and excuse in himself. It gives a city whose pride and plenty left the poor unhelped and whose men

also sought to do violence to strangers, and it says the Lord saw it and judged it. Lot is “just” in Peter’s words, and the account sets the judgment beside deliverance.

Related Reading

Companions: Genesis, Ezekiel and Jude.

6. Does Romans 10:9–10 Make Confession a Condition of the Body's Salvation?

THE ANSWER

No, because Romans 10 is not addressed to the Body. It sits inside Romans 9–11, Paul's address to Israel, and verse 9 is Israel's covenantal salvation formula, drawn from Deuteronomy 30. Confession belongs to that formula and is Israel's covenantal expression. It has no saving function for the Body, which is saved by belief alone in the gospel Paul preached (1 Corinthians 15:1–4; Ephesians 2:8–9).

Where the Verse Stands

Romans 10 begins with Paul's prayer for Israel: "my heart's desire and prayer to God for Israel is, that they might be saved." The whole of chapters 9 to 11 is about Israel: their present unbelief, their zeal "not according to knowledge," their own righteousness set against God's, and the word of Moses that Paul quotes in verse 8. The mouth-and-heart pattern of verse 9 comes from Deuteronomy 30:14, which was spoken to Israel as a people under covenant. Verses 9 and 10 give what Israel is asked to do about their Messiah: confess him as Lord and believe that God raised him from the dead.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
10:1–4	"Brethren, my heart's desire and prayer to God for Israel is, that they might be saved. For I bear them record that they have a zeal of God, but not according to knowledge. For they being ignorant of God's righteousness, and going about to establish their own righteousness, have not submitted themselves unto the righteousness of God. For Christ is the end of the law for righteousness to every one that believeth."	The subject is Israel. Israel's own righteousness against God's.
10:5–8	"For Moses describeth the righteousness which is of the law, That the man which doeth those things shall live by them. But the righteousness which is of faith speaketh on this wise, Say not in thine heart, Who shall ascend into heaven? (that is, to bring Christ down from above:) Or, Who shall descend into the deep? (that is, to bring up Christ again from the dead.) But what saith it? The word is nigh thee, even in thy mouth, and in thy heart: that is, the word of faith, which we preach;"	Moses' word, quoted. The word is "nigh thee, even in thy mouth, and in thy heart."
10:9–10	"That if thou shalt confess with thy mouth the Lord Jesus, and shalt believe in thine heart that God hath raised him from the dead, thou shalt be saved. For with the heart man believeth unto righteousness; and with the mouth confession is made unto salvation."	Mouth then heart in verse 9; heart then mouth in verse 10.

Deut 30:14	"But the word is very nigh unto thee, in thy mouth, and in thy heart, that thou mayest do it."	The source of the pairing, spoken to Israel.
1 Cor 15:1–4	"Moreover, brethren, I declare unto you the gospel which I preached unto you, which also ye have received, and wherein ye stand; By which also ye are saved, if ye keep in memory what I preached unto you, unless ye have believed in vain. For I delivered unto you first of all that which I also received, how that Christ died for our sins according to the scriptures; And that he was buried, and that he rose again the third day according to the scriptures:"	The gospel Paul preached to the Body. No confession is named.
Eph 2:8–9	"For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves: it is the gift of God: Not of works, lest any man should boast."	The Body is saved through faith, "not of works."

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** Romans 10 opens with "for Israel," and the chapter's subject is Israel's unbelief and Israel's righteousness (10:1–4). Chapters 9 to 11 are Paul's address to Israel.
- **Stated:** the pairing "in thy mouth, and in thy heart" is Moses' (Deuteronomy 30:14), spoken to Israel, and Paul quotes it in 10:8. Verse 9 builds Israel's response on that pairing.
- **Stated:** the gospel Paul preached to the Body names the death, burial and rising of Christ and says the Body is saved by believing it, "by grace… through faith… not of works" (1 Corinthians 15:1–4; Ephesians 2:8–9). Neither passage names a mouth-act.
- **Shown by the context:** verse 9 is Israel's covenantal formula. It belongs to the Deuteronomy 30 pattern, it is addressed to the people Paul is praying for, and it is not the entry point of the Body into Christ. It is also not the gospel Paul preached in 1 Corinthians 15:1–4.
- **Shown by the context:** confession in verses 9 and 10 is part of what Israel is asked to do, not a part of the Body's salvation. The Body is saved by belief alone, with no mouth-act, ritual or verbal expression added, and confession is not part of the gospel of the grace of God.
- **Inferred:** that the saying "no difference between the Jew and the Greek" (10:12) and the words "whosoever shall call" (10:13) are Paul reporting how wide the Lord's name reaches inside his address to Israel, and that they do not turn verse 9 into the Body's formula. The text does not say what part the Greek has in Israel's formula, and the entry does not decide it.

The Other Readings

Confession as the outward expression of the faith that saves, for every believer. Douglas Moo (*The Epistle to the Romans*, NICNT) describes confession as an outgrowth of saving faith and not a second condition, and counts belief in the heart as the crucial requirement. This reading takes Romans 10 as written to the Body and places confession inside the Body's salvation, which this entry does not do.
Confession as submission to lordship. John MacArthur (*The Gospel According to Jesus*) reads "Lord" as a confession of surrender that belongs to saving faith, and applies it to every believer. It also makes confession part of salvation. **Confession as a required act for every believer.** Some traditions treat the confession as a condition

added to belief. This has to make Romans 10:9 and Ephesians 2:8–9 one message.
Israel's covenantal formula. This is the reading taken here.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Israel's covenantal formula	Romans 10:9 is the formula for Israel; confession is Israel's covenantal expression.	The text does not say what part the Greek has in verses 12–13.
Expression of saving faith for all	Confession expresses the faith that saves anyone.	Puts Romans 10 inside the Body's salvation; 1 Corinthians 15:1–4 names no confession.
Submission to lordship	Saving faith includes surrender, confessed.	Adds a mouth-act to the Body's salvation.
A required act for all	Confession is a second condition for every believer.	Ephesians 2:8–9 says "not of works."

What It Means for the Reader

The reader who belongs to the Body is saved by believing the gospel Paul preached, and nothing is added to it: no confession, no mouth-act, no ritual. Romans 10:9 is Israel's formula and should not be used as a test, a script or a condition for the Body. The passage shows what Israel is asked to do about its Messiah, and the reader can read it as that without placing himself under it.

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 54, Justification. **Companions:** Romans.

7. What Does It Mean to “Grieve Not the Holy Spirit of God”?

THE ANSWER

It is a command about conduct. The sins around it (lying, wrath that gives the devil a place, corrupt speech, bitterness) grieve the Spirit who dwells in the believer, yet the same verse says the believer is “sealed unto the day of redemption.” Grieving affects fellowship and the believer’s walk, not the security of the seal.

Where the Verse Stands

Verse 30 sits inside a block that begins at 4:25 with “Wherefore putting away lying,” and ends at 4:32 with forgiveness. Paul has just told the Ephesians to put off the old way and put on the new (4:22–24, in the lead-up), and he now gives the new life in particulars: truth with the neighbour, anger that does not sin, honest work, speech that edifies. The command about the Spirit is the centre of the list, and the reason given is the seal.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
4:25–27	“Wherefore putting away lying, speak every man truth with his neighbour: for we are members one of another. Be ye angry, and sin not: let not the sun go down upon your wrath: Neither give place to the devil.”	Lying, wrath. “Give place to the devil.”
4:28–29	“Let him that stole steal no more: but rather let him labour, working with his hands the thing which is good, that he may have to give to him that needeth. Let no corrupt communication proceed out of your mouth, but that which is good to the use of edifying, that it may minister grace unto the hearers.”	Stealing, corrupt speech; the good in their place.
4:30	“And grieve not the holy Spirit of God, whereby ye are sealed unto the day of redemption.”	The Spirit can be grieved. The seal runs “unto the day of redemption.”
4:31–32	“Let all bitterness, and wrath, and anger, and clamour, and evil speaking, be put away from you, with all malice: And be ye kind one to another, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, even as God for Christ’s sake hath forgiven you.”	Bitterness, wrath, anger, clamour, malice; kindness and forgiveness.

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** the command is “grieve not the holy Spirit of God,” and the Spirit is the one “whereby ye are sealed unto the day of redemption.”
- **Stated:** the verses on either side name the conduct: lying, wrath held overnight, giving place to the devil, stealing, corrupt communication, bitterness, anger, clamour, evil speaking and malice.
- **Shown by the context:** the Spirit is treated as a person who can be grieved. Grief is a response to wrong done by those he is near, and the list shows the wrongs.

- **Shown by the context:** the seal's length, "unto the day of redemption," is stated in the same verse as the warning. Paul gives the Ephesians the security and the command together and does not suggest that grieving breaks the seal.
- **Inferred:** that grieving the Spirit affects the believer's fellowship and his testimony and not his standing. The text states the command and the seal in one sentence and does not say what grieving costs the believer beyond the Spirit's grief.

The Other Readings

Grieving can end in loss of salvation. I. Howard Marshall (*Kept by the Power of God*) holds that a believer can fall away and be lost, and reads warnings of this kind as bearing on that possibility. This reading has to explain a seal that lasts "unto the day of redemption." **Grieving as a loss of the Spirit's power or joy.** This reading treats the warning as bearing on the believer's experience of the Spirit's presence without removing the Spirit. The text does not mention power or joy. **Grieving as a fellowship matter.** This is the reading taken here.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Conduct that grieves; the seal stays	The sins listed grieve the Spirit and the seal holds.	The text does not say what grieving costs the believer.
Loss of salvation	The believer who grieves the Spirit can be lost.	The seal runs "unto the day of redemption."
Loss of power or joy	Grieving dulls the Spirit's work in the believer.	Power and joy are not named in the passage.

What It Means for the Reader

The reader's bitterness, evil speaking and untruth are not small matters, because the Spirit who seals the believer is grieved by them. The reader can also be sure, from the same verse, that the Spirit does not leave when he is grieved. The command is a call to walk in kindness and forgiveness "even as God for Christ's sake hath forgiven you."

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 46, Secure in Christ. **Companions:** Ephesians.

8. To Whom Are the Words “Well Done, Thou Good and Faithful Servant” Spoken?

THE ANSWER

They are the King’s words to faithful servants in Israel’s kingdom, in a parable given on the Mount of Olives. The reward is rule “over many things” and entering “the joy of thy lord.” The passage is not the Body’s judgment seat.

Where the Verse Stands

The words stand in Matthew 25:21, in the parable of the talents, and the parable belongs to a section of the Lord’s discourse that begins at 24:45 with “a faithful and wise servant, whom his lord hath made ruler over his household.” Luke’s parallel in 19:11–27 is told “because he was nigh to Jerusalem, and because they thought that the kingdom of God should immediately appear.” In both, the lord goes away and returns, and the reward is authority in his kingdom.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
Matt 24:45–47	“Who then is a faithful and wise servant, whom his lord hath made ruler over his household, to give them meat in due season? Blessed is that servant, whom his lord when he cometh shall find so doing. Verily I say unto you, That he shall make him ruler over all his goods.”	The section opens on a servant made ruler over a household.
Matt 25:14–15	“For the kingdom of heaven is as a man travelling into a far country, who called his own servants, and delivered unto them his goods. And unto one he gave five talents, to another two, and to another one; to every man according to his several ability; and straightway took his journey.”	“The kingdom of heaven is as.” The lord leaves.
Matt 25:21	“His lord said unto him, Well done, thou good and faithful servant: thou hast been faithful over a few things, I will make thee ruler over many things: enter thou into the joy of thy lord.”	The words. The reward is rule and the lord’s joy.
Matt 25:30	“And cast ye the unprofitable servant into outer darkness: there shall be weeping and gnashing of teeth.”	The unfaithful servant is cast out.
Luke 19:11–12	“And as they heard these things, he added and spake a parable, because he was nigh to Jerusalem, and because they thought that the kingdom of God should immediately appear. He said therefore, A certain nobleman went into a far country to receive for himself a kingdom, and to return.”	The setting is the expectation of the kingdom.

Luke 19:17	“And he said unto him, Well, thou good servant: because thou hast been faithful in a very little, have thou authority over ten cities.”	The reward is authority over cities.

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** Matthew 25:14 begins “the kingdom of heaven is as,” and the lord’s reward is rule: “I will make thee ruler over many things.” Luke’s reward is “authority over ten cities.”
- **Stated:** Luke’s parable is told “because they thought that the kingdom of God should immediately appear,” and the nobleman goes “to receive for himself a kingdom, and to return.”
- **Shown by the context:** the parable is part of a discourse about the Lord’s coming (24:45 to 25:30) and ends in the same shape as it began: a servant ruled or cast out. The other end of the section is the unfaithful servant who says “My lord delayeth his coming” (24:48), and the servants who are made rulers at his return.
- **Shown by the context:** the reward is the kingdom’s own: authority and the joy of the lord. It is not the Body’s account at the judgment seat, which Paul gives separately in his own letters (1 Corinthians 3:12–15; 2 Corinthians 5:10).
- **Inferred:** that the servants are Israel’s servants at the King’s return, as the setting in Matthew’s discourse and Luke’s kingdom expectation indicate. The text does not name Israel in the parable itself; the audience and the kingdom setting carry the weight.

The Other Readings

Servants of every age. Most modern commentaries read the servants as disciples in general, and apply the parable to Christians now. This reading takes the parables of this section as addressed to the disciples and bearing on the believer’s readiness. It must carry the kingdom setting over to the church. **The Body at the judgment seat.** This takes “well done” as the Lord’s commendation at his judgment seat. It has to explain the setting in the Lord’s coming and the kingdom reward, and it makes the Body’s account a matter of Matthew 25. **Israel’s servants at the King’s return.** This is the reading taken here.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Israel’s servants at the return	The King’s commendation to faithful servants of the kingdom.	The text does not name Israel in the parable.
Disciples of every age	The parable applies to Christians now.	The kingdom setting; the reward is rule at his return.
The judgment seat	The Lord’s “well done” to the Body.	The Lord’s coming is the setting, and the reward is rule.

What It Means for the Reader

The reader should not read this commendation as spoken to the Body on the day of its accounting. The Body’s accounting is given in its own letters. The parable teaches faithfulness in what the lord has committed to his servants while he is away, and it promises authority in his kingdom when he returns.

Related Reading

Parable Studies: The Talents; The Minas. **Commentary Series:** Gospel, Volume 3; Prophecy & Mystery, Volume 5. **Companions:** Matthew and Luke.

9. What Does “The Kingdom of Heaven Suffereth Violence” Mean?

THE ANSWER

The kingdom has been assaulted since the days of John. John is in prison when the saying is spoken, and “the violent” who “take it by force” are its opponents. The saying is about the kingdom’s resistance, not about eager seekers pressing in.

Where the Verse Stands

Matthew 11 opens with John “in the prison,” sending two disciples to ask, “Art thou he that should come, or do we look for another?” The Lord answers by pointing to his works, and then speaks of John to the multitudes. John had been put in prison for telling Herod “It is not lawful for thee to have her” (14:3–4). The saying in verse 12 comes in the Lord’s tribute to John, and it measures the kingdom’s history “from the days of John the Baptist until now.”

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
11:2–3	“Now when John had heard in the prison the works of Christ, he sent two of his disciples, And said unto him, Art thou he that should come, or do we look for another?”	John is in prison.
11:11–12	“Verily I say unto you, Among them that are born of women there hath not risen a greater than John the Baptist: notwithstanding he that is least in the kingdom of heaven is greater than he. And from the days of John the Baptist until now the kingdom of heaven suffereth violence, and the violent take it by force.”	The kingdom “suffereth violence” “from the days of John.”
11:13–14	“For all the prophets and the law prophesied until John. And if ye will receive it, this is Elias, which was for to come.”	John is the herald; Israel is offered the choice.
14:3–5	“For Herod had laid hold on John, and bound him, and put him in prison for Herodias’ sake, his brother Philip’s wife. For John said unto him, It is not lawful for thee to have her. And when he would have put him to death, he feared the multitude, because they counted him as a prophet.”	The herald is bound and nearly killed for his rebuke.
Luke 16:16	“The law and the prophets were until John: since that time the kingdom of God is preached, and every man presseth into it.”	A different setting and wording.

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** the kingdom “suffereth violence, and the violent take it by force,” from “the days of John the Baptist until now.”

- **Stated:** John is in prison as the saying is spoken (11:2), and Matthew tells why: Herod had "bound him, and put him in prison" for John's rebuke (14:3–4).
- **Shown by the context:** the Lord has just said "ye will receive it, this is Elias" (11:14), an offer to Israel that depends on receiving. Verse 12 follows by saying the herald is already bound and the kingdom is under assault.
- **Shown by the context:** Luke 16:16 has its own wording, "every man presseth into it," in its own setting. Matthew's sentence is read by Matthew's surroundings, and the two are not made one saying.
- **Inferred:** that the violent are those who oppose, as Herod did, and that "take it by force" is the seizing and holding back of the kingdom by force. The text does not name the violent in the verse.

The Other Readings

Eager seekers pressing in. This reads the violent as people who press into the kingdom with zeal, and cites Luke 16:16. This reading has to explain why the verse follows John's imprisonment and Herod's act. **The kingdom advances with power.** This takes the verb in a sense of the kingdom moving forcefully, and has to explain "the violent take it by force." **The kingdom is assaulted.** This is the reading taken here.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Assaulted by opponents	The kingdom is attacked and held back since John.	The verse does not name the violent.
Eager seekers pressing in	Zealous people press in; Luke 16:16.	Follows John's imprisonment; "take it by force."
The kingdom advances	The kingdom goes forward with force.	"The violent take it by force."

What It Means for the Reader

The saying is about the kingdom's history in Israel's ministry, not about how a believer should seek. The one who announced it was imprisoned, and the kingdom was met with force. The reader sees what the Lord saw: the offer was real and the opposition was real.

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 41, Kingdom of God or Kingdom of Heaven. **Commentary Series:** Gospel, Volume 2. **Companions:** Matthew.

10. Is the “Everlasting Father” of Isaiah 9:6 God the Father?

THE ANSWER

The title belongs to the child born, who sits on David’s throne. It names him as a father to his people who does not die, a role Isaiah himself gives to a faithful steward, “a father to the inhabitants of Jerusalem.” It does not say the Son is the Father.

Where the Verse Stands

Isaiah 9:1–7 answers the gloom of the end of chapter 8. The people “that walked in darkness have seen a great light,” and the reason follows: “unto us a child is born, unto us a son is given.” The child bears a list of names and a government that has no end “upon the throne of David.” The passage sits inside Isaiah 7 to 12, a section about the house of David and the promise to it.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
9:2	“The people that walked in darkness have seen a great light: they that dwell in the land of the shadow of death, upon them hath the light shined.”	Light to those in darkness.
9:6	“For unto us a child is born, unto us a son is given: and the government shall be upon his shoulder: and his name shall be called Wonderful, Counsellor, The mighty God, The everlasting Father, The Prince of Peace.”	A child “born,” a son “given.” Five names.
9:7	“Of the increase of his government and peace there shall be no end, upon the throne of David, and upon his kingdom, to order it, and to establish it with judgment and with justice from henceforth even for ever. The zeal of the Lord of hosts will perform this.”	The throne of David; no end.
22:20–22	“And it shall come to pass in that day, that I will call my servant Eliakim the son of Hilkiah: And I will clothe him with thy robe, and strengthen him with thy girdle, and I will commit thy government into his hand: and he shall be a father to the inhabitants of Jerusalem, and to the house of Judah. And the key of the house of David will I lay upon his shoulder; so he shall open, and none shall shut; and he shall shut, and none shall open.”	Government, the key of David’s house “upon his shoulder,” “a father to the inhabitants.”
Job 29:16	“I was a father to the poor: and the cause which I knew not I searched out.”	“A father” as a role of care.

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** the child is “born” and a son is “given,” and the government is “upon his shoulder.” The five names are given to him, and the government is “upon the throne of David.”
- **Stated:** Isaiah 22:21 says Eliakim “shall be a father to the inhabitants of Jerusalem, and to the house of Judah,” and 22:22 lays “the key of the house of David” on his shoulder. Government on the shoulder and a father to the people occur together there too.
- **Shown by the context:** the names are a list of titles of the king’s office and character. The list includes “The mighty God,” which says the child is more than a man, and “The everlasting Father,” which names the care he gives his people for ever, because his government “shall be no end.”
- **Shown by the context:** Job’s “I was a father to the poor” shows “father” as a word for the one who protects and provides. The word describes what the king is to the people.
- **Inferred:** that “everlasting Father” is the title of the Davidic King as the unending father of his people. The text does not say in the verse that the Son is the Father in person, and it does not need to.

The Other Readings

The Son is the Father. Some read the title as identifying the Son with the Father, a reading associated with Oneness teaching. It has to explain “a son is given” in the same verse. **Father of eternity.** Many commentaries read the child as the Messiah and the title as the one whose fatherly care lasts for ever. That is the reading taken here, and it treats the verse as describing the king’s relation to his people, not his identity with the Father. **A title for a human king.** This takes the names as honorific for a royal child in the line of David and has to explain “The mighty God.”

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Unending father of his people	The Davidic King’s care for his people, for ever.	The verse does not state the Son’s relation to the Father.
The Son is the Father	The title identifies Son and Father.	“A son is given”; the title sits in a list of names.
A human king’s honorific	Titles for a royal child.	“The mighty God” and a throne with no end.

What It Means for the Reader

The verse promises a King on David’s throne whose government never ends and whose care for his people never ends. The title is not a statement about who the Son is in himself but about what the King is to those he rules, and Isaiah’s own book shows a father to the inhabitants of Jerusalem as the shape of such rule.

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 63, Isaiah 7:13–16; Study 73, The Davidic Covenant.
Commentary Series: Covenantal, Volume 5. **Companions:** Isaiah.

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